



Parasha Vezot Haberakhah – Succession planning

(Deuteronomy 33:1 – 34:12)

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As Jewmaica forged ahead in re-establishing a Portuguese Jewish community in Jamaica, we encouraged all descendants of Israel (those Spanish Portuguese, and we call our Igbo {Heebo/Eboe/Ibo} brothers and others) to join us in rebuilding this, our goodly heritage.

“ אֵין כָּאֵל יִשְׁרָאֵן רֹכֵב שָׁמַיִם בְּעֶזְרָהּ וּבִגְאוּתוֹ שְׁחָקִים ”

“O Jeshurun, there is none like God, riding through the heavens to help you,
through the skies in His majesty.”

[Deuteronomy 33:26]

We are now at the point where we read the last portion of the Torah, parasha – *Vezot HaBerakhah* (See/behold blessings). The parasha is being read at the culmination of the annual Torah reading on Simchat Torah and so is meant to further elevate the *kahal* at the festivities of *Shemini Atzeret*. At which juncture we complete *sefer Devarim* –and will start anew the reading of the Torah next week with the book of *Bereshit* (Genesis).

In *Vezot HaBerakhah*, even after the many struggles, and prophetic warnings, Moses our Teacher of Blessed Memory is now departing; and like our fathers before him: Abraham, Isaac and Yisrael, he pronounces on us an enduring blessing. This blessing by our Teacher Moses still remains and cannot be undone even by the might or usurpation by the enemies of *Am Yisrael*. (See Deuteronomy 33: 6 – 29). And “Never again did there arise in Israel a prophet like Moses—whom יהוה singled out, face to face...” [Deuteronomy 34:10]

As we conclude with Zevot HaBerakhah (Behold Blessings) the Torah solidifies a previous message that Moses had sought to teach us. That message is: the Torah presents a lasting blessing of good things to endure throughout the generations of *Am Yisrael* unending, and certainly in this world that we live not in a hypothetical yonder.

Kahal Yisrael continues to experience the arrays of blessing as seen in the preceding parashiyot through some solid steps, first of which is: the sole worship of יהוה and being free of avoda zarah (since there is only one God – He being without parents, siblings or children – next week we will learn again, in Genesis, that He alone made the heaven and earth). Additionally the Kahal is to achieve these blessings through the establishment of a accessible, righteous judicial system free of bribes and where justice is accessible to all irrespective of persons, accessibility to landed heritage (with points of systematic reset); institutionalized communal kindness and the importance of individual and collection actions and repercussion, these among others we will all revisit in the coming weeks.

Paramount though, is that the Torah frames these concepts (knowledge) within the importance of parent to children education – training starts in the home (See Deuteronomy 6:4-9)

“Hear, O Israel! יהוה is our God, יהוה alone”

This importance of training extends to the communal and national leadership and includes training for successive leadership(s) – Semeikha. Hence we see Moshe our Teacher on his departure ensuring the continuation having trained Joshua but by leadership, hence we read:

“Now Joshua son of Nun was filled with the spirit of wisdom because Moses had laid his hands upon him; and the Israelites heeded him, doing as יהוה had commanded Moses.”

[Deuteronomy 34:9]

Through the teaching of our Rabbis, next week we again embark on our annual Torah reading (starting at Genesis). This presents us with this re-new opportunity to apply ourselves to learning and to continue the endless *chain of custody* in passing this knowledge of the greatness of יהוה to our next generation.

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ

IN THE BEGINNING God created the heaven and the earth.

Chag Sameach v’ Shabbat Shalom